RESEARCH ARTICLE CLASS PROJECT

Lifespan is Effected by Military Status in Males Buried at the Sunset Hill Cemetery, Valdosta, Georgia

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Abstract

Purpose: This project describes lifespan patterns in cemetery records and examines variation by sex and marital status. [you can do military service of males or pre- and post- a particular year - default 1930]

Methods: Recorded available birth and death information from gravestones and classified selected characteristics using evidence visible on the stones and in burial arrangements. [Go into much greater detail in the methods section]

Results: [Summarize the principal patterns in the class data.]

Conclusions: [State what the observed patterns suggest and note limitations. Distinguish lifespan in this cemetery sample from population life expectancy.]

Keywords: cemetery records; lifespan; survivorship; marital status; historical demography

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Background

Cemetery records provide individual birth and death dates that can be used to describe lifespan among people represented in a burial ground. These records are a non-random sample: cemetery access, preservation of markers, migration, family burial practices, and the choice of graves to record may all affect which people appear in the dataset. The analyses below therefore describe the collected sample and should not be treated as direct estimates of lifespan for an entire town or historical population.

Hypotheses

3. **Military service and lifespan:** I hypothesize that male records marked as military service will show [greater / lower / similar] lifespan than records not marked for service because [brief rationale].

Methods

Complete the prompts below. Replace bracketed text with details from the field visit and the final class dataset.

Field site and sampling

- **Where did you go?** [Cemetery name, location, and any relevant site characteristics.]
- **What date and time of day did you collect records?** [Date, start/end time, and weather or visibility conditions if relevant.]
- **What part of the cemetery did you sample?** [Section, row, plot area, or a map-based description.]
- **How did you choose graves?** [Describe whether sampling was systematic, opportunistic, or based on another rule.]
- **How did you handle nearby graves and family plots?** [Explain whether neighboring graves were recorded to capture families, or whether sampling moved between plots to avoid over-representing one family.]

Recorded information and variable definitions

- **What information did you record from each marker?** [For example: name, birth date or year, death date or year, age at death, sex/gender as recorded or inferred, marriage indicator, military indicator, and inscription details.]
- **How was lifespan calculated?** [State whether age was transcribed from the marker or calculated as death year minus birth year, and how partial dates were handled.]
- **How did you determine marital status?** [Explain evidence such as "wife," "husband," spouse names, or paired markers. If a joint grave was used as evidence, state that this is an inference and describe the rule.]
- **How did you determine military service?** [Describe explicit evidence such as service branch, rank, unit, or veteran symbols. Explain how uncertain cases were coded.]
- **How did you determine sex or gender?** [Describe what was explicitly recorded and what, if anything, was inferred. Do not present an inference as a confirmed identity.]
- **How were missing, illegible, or ambiguous records handled?** [State exclusion and coding rules.]

Dataset and analysis

- **How many records were collected by you?** [n =]
- **How many records were included in the final analysis?** [n = ; explain exclusions.]
- **Were records aggregated with the class dataset?** [Yes / no. If yes, describe how duplicates and conflicting entries were checked.]
- **What summaries or plots were produced?** [Describe group summaries and empirical survivorship curves, including how categories were defined.]
- **What are the limits of the sample?** [Discuss marker preservation, incomplete dates, cemetery selection, sampling strategy, and any other relevant limitations.]

Lifespan by sex and military service

Sex	Military	n	Mean	SD	Median	Minimum	Maximum
f	n	342	71.1	21.9	76.0	0	105
m	n	340	61.9	23.6	66.0	0	114
m	y	70	63.8	20.0	67.5	21	96

Figure 1: Summary of lifespan by sex and by marrital status for each sex.

Results

The summary table in Figure 1 shows non-substantial differences in recorded lifespan by military status. Military Males had a mean lifespan of 63.8 years (SD = 20.4; n = 70), compared with 29.7 years (SD = 7.1; n = 3) for females. The marital-status breakdown is more tentative because each subgroup contains only one or two records. Among males, the two married individuals had a mean lifespan of 70.5 years (SD = 6.4), while the one unmarried individual lived 36 years. Among females, the one married individual lived 36 years, compared with a mean of 26.5 years (SD = 6.4) for the two unmarried individuals. These small subgroup sizes make the values descriptive; they do not support broad conclusions about sex or marital status.

The sex-specific survivorship curves in Figure 2 show a different pattern: the plotted means are 61.1 years for males and 57.3 years for females. The male curve remains higher through much of the earlier and middle lifespan, while the female curve reaches the 50% survival point later. The curves are close and change relative position, so the figure suggests that the sex difference depends on which part of the lifespan distribution is considered. The median markers indicate where each group's observed curve reaches 50% surviving; they are distinct from the mean values shown in the legend.

Discussion

Military Status and Effect on Lifespan We did not find significant differences between military men and men not servicing in the military in respect to lifespan for our sample from the Sunset Hill cemetery in Valdosta, Georgia. Instead, we found, contrary to expectations of our hypothesis, that military men lived 2 years longer than non-military men. We believe this pattern can be explained in two ways; first, we did not get individuals that died in war buried at the Sunset Hill cemetery, as many of those invidiuals were buried

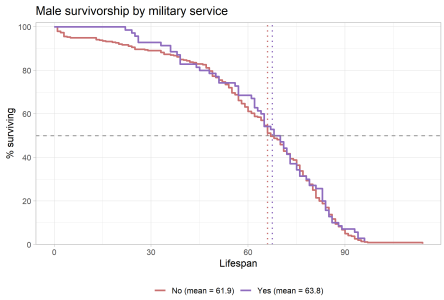


Figure 2: Survivorship curves by sex. The y-axis shows the percentage of the cemetery sample surviving to each lifespan. Dotted vertical lines mark the median lifespan for each sex, where the curve reaches 50%.

in Arlington, and secondly, we anticipated that military men, after having made it thorugh war, would exhibit similar life history trends as those not having served. Because we did not capture the death of youth service members, we instead get a very similar life history curve between both groups. However, we did hypothesize that men serving in the miliary may exhibit higher rates of cancer or geriatric diseases due to exposure to chemicals during basic training and service. While this could still be true, the life history table does not capture that effect.

References